The Bell That Hissed

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 13

Fern Lodge's reply sack was waiting. Its signal bell was not doing nearly as well. A loose cloth edge lay against the clapper. Nib blew at it with a magnificent puff, and the bell answered with the faintest possible hiss. Lark found the stand's short instruction.

“A very quiet bell,” Nib whispered suspiciously. “A bell wearing a scarf,” Lark replied gently.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

> **pack**

“In bell and fill, the two l letters share one /l/ sound,” Lark explained clearly. “Puff ends with one /f/ written ff. Hiss ends with one /s/ written ss. We still blend the sounds once each; extra letters don't ask for extra little vowels.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try puff, fill, bell, hiss. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read bell on the stand note,” Lark invited gently. “Which part needs room to move?”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

> **Sam can fill. Pat can puff.**

“Which friend can puff?” Lark asked warmly. “Look at the word after can in each sentence.”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Nib lifted the loose cloth and fixed it clear of the clapper. The bell rang once. They collected Fern Lodge's reply from the agreed hook. On the return path they used their own notes: the Mill reply waited in its letter bin, and Reed Hut's reply waited in its flap. Three replies settled into three separate bag pockets.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write bell beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

The cloth stayed clear and the bell stayed useful. With every invitation delivered and every reply collected, the crew followed the familiar dry path back to camp. Nothing was still waiting at an unvisited stop.